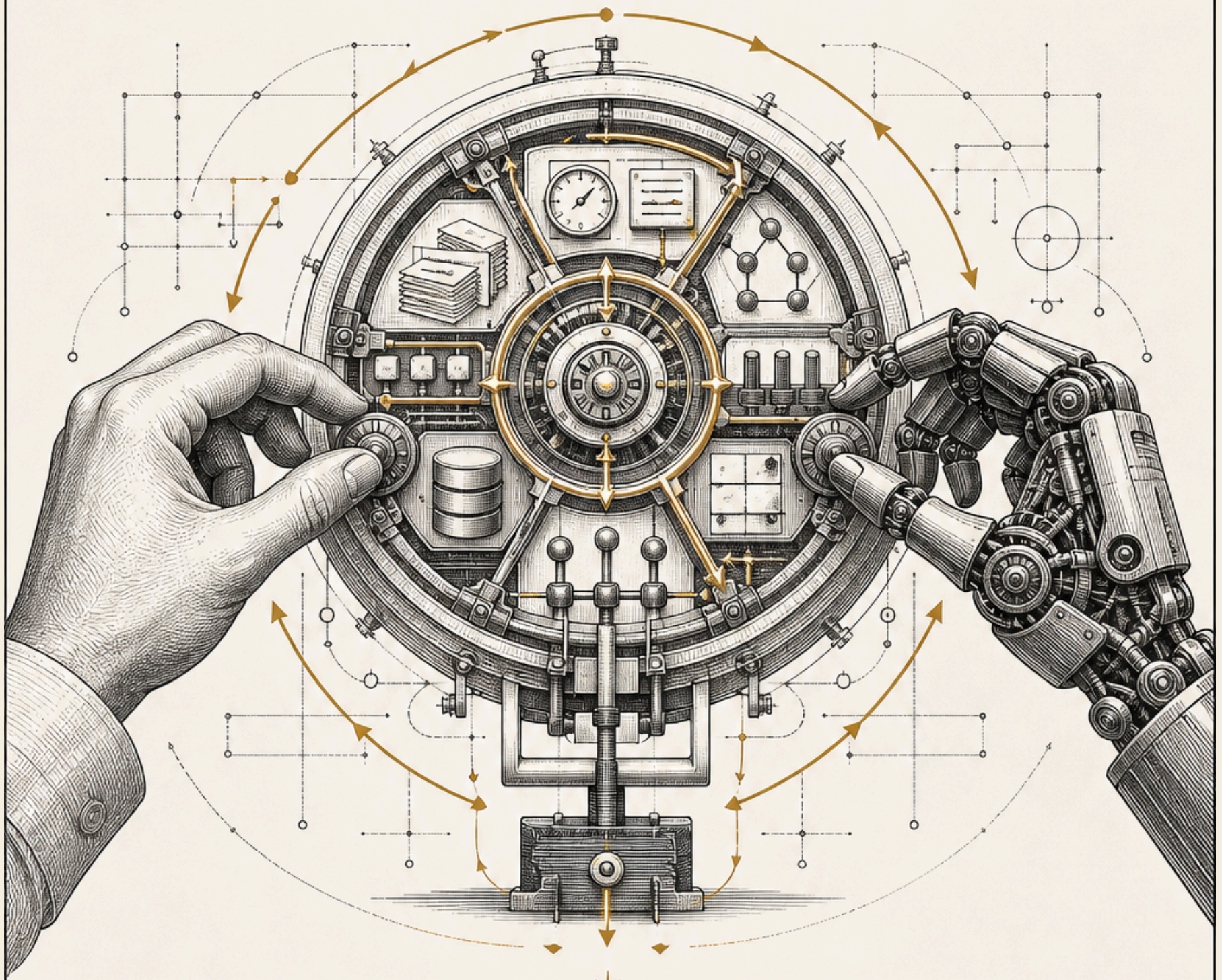


From Copilot to Colleague

HOW AI ENGINEERING TURNS
MODELS INTO DEPENDABLE SYSTEMS



Timur Isachenko

**People stopped
wanting an answer.
They started wanting
the work done.**

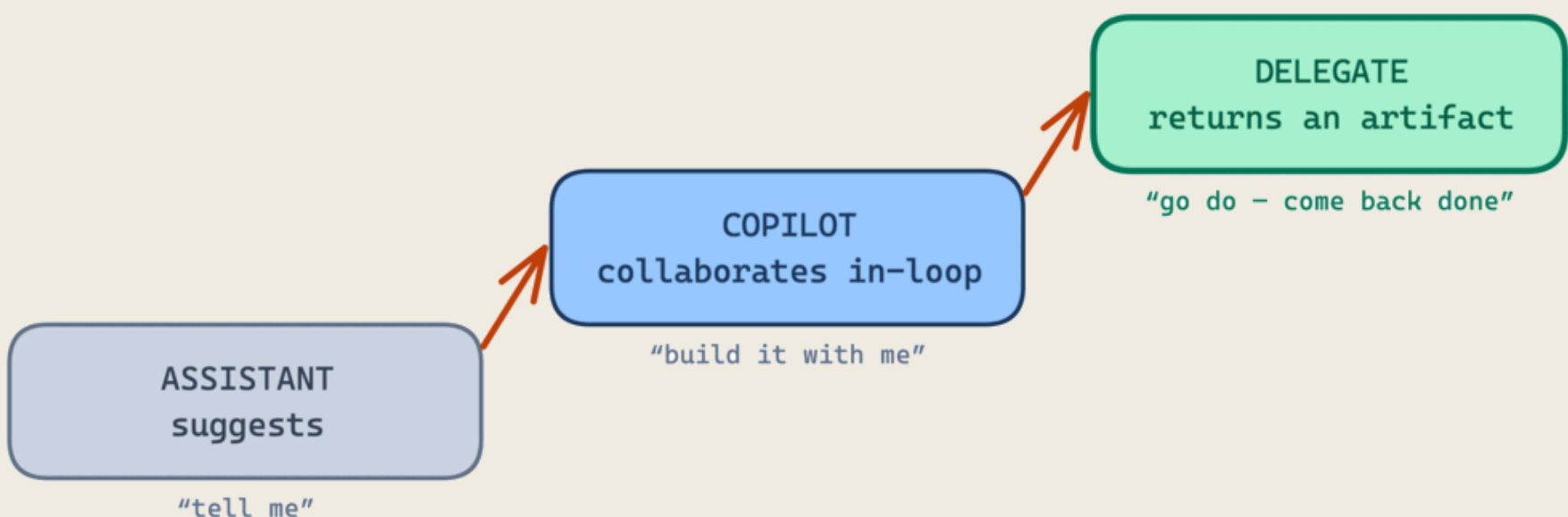
The verb went from “*tell me*” to “*go do.*”

Assistant. Copilot. Delegate.

CHAPTER 1 · FIGURE 1

Three rungs: assistant, copilot, delegate

Each rung delegates more of the work – and more of the failure surface.



rising delegation → rising trust required

The book's frontier: the engineering difficulty clusters on the third rung.

– Joel Hron, CTO Thomson Reuters · corpus video #206

Sorted by where the human sits relative to the loop. Moving between them isn't a scale-up — it changes what the system has to be.

The failure surface stretches

CHAPTER 1 · THE SHIFT: FROM ASSISTANT TO DELEGATE

The Failure Surface Stretches

Suggestion is supervised by construction. Delegation isn't.

ASSISTANT – “tell me” · human reads every word

Ask

Suggest

Human reads ✓

failure surface: one response

a wrong suggestion = a wrong sentence, caught in context

DELEGATE – “go do” · human waits for the result

Delegate

step 1

step 2 x

step 3 built on

step 4 built on

Review 👁

failure surface: the whole workflow

a wrong delegated action = a wrong artifact other work now depends on

The error no longer surfaces when it happens – it surfaces later, after it has been built on.

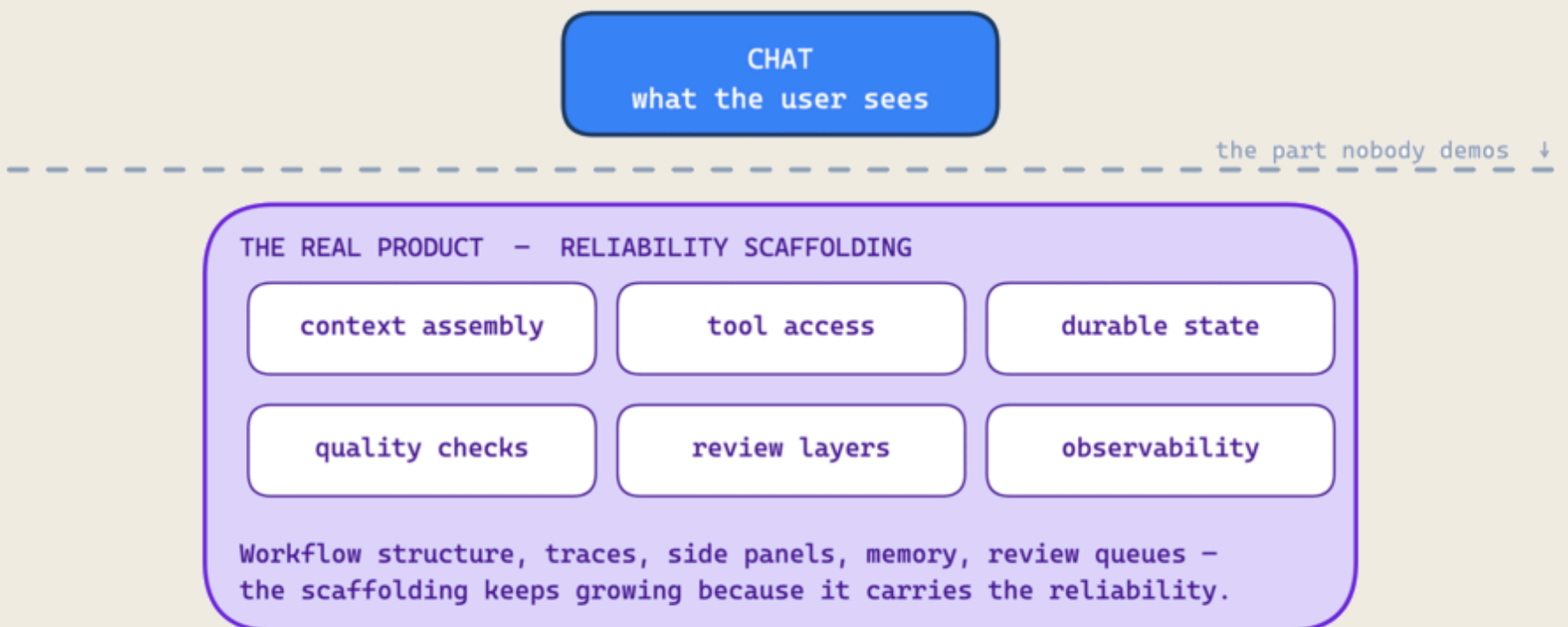
A wrong suggestion is a wrong sentence, caught in context. A wrong delegated action is a wrong artifact that later work already depends on.

The chat box was always the smallest part

CHAPTER 1 · FIGURE 3

Chat is the visible surface

Once AI does real work, the surrounding system does the reliability work.



"Vertical AI and complex agents need more than just the chat."

— Jacob Lauritzen, CTO Legora · corpus video #3

The apparatus underneath is the product: context, tools, evals, durable state, review, observability. A missing organ is a reliability gap — not a leaner design.

Every claim has a receipt

No claim ships without a video id, a timestamp, and a verbatim quote — checked against the transcript. Every claim links to the exact second it came from.

“The main bottleneck is becoming the tool call.”

— Neil Zeghidour, Gadium AI

ANCHOR P_RI1kCkRbo 00:07:17 → 00:07:19 ·
verbatim

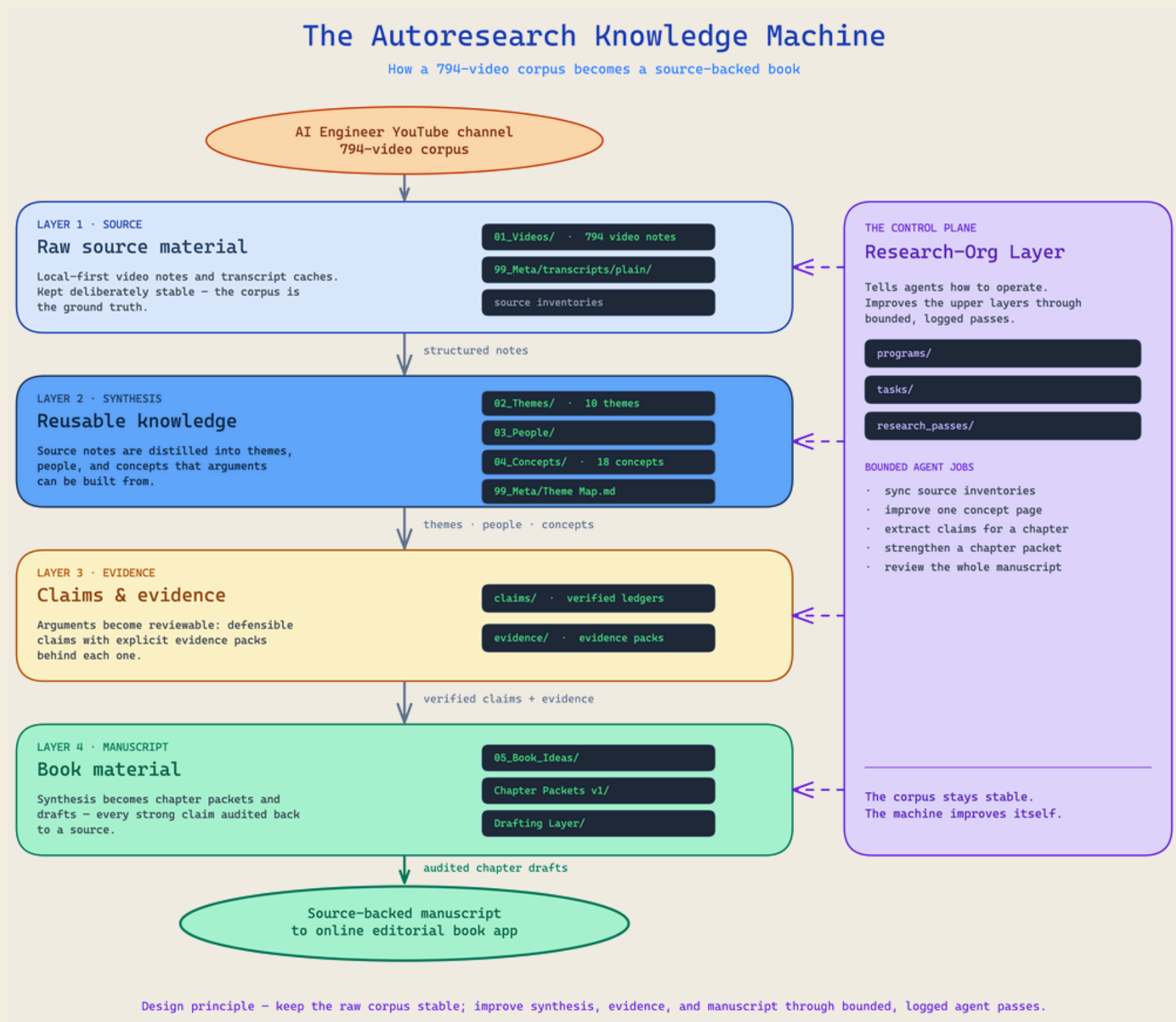
Graded by three rival models

Each chapter is scored on six dimensions by three model families — Llama-3.3, Qwen-2.5, DeepSeek. The *median* is the verdict, so no model flatters its own style.

CHAPTER	HUMAN	VOICE	EVIDENCE	DEFENS.
1 · The Shift	87	90	90	90
4 · Evals	89	92	90	94
5 · Context	89	85	90	84
9 · AI-Native Org	88	85	78	92

Where the three disagree by >20 points, the cell is flagged — an LLM-as-judge honest about its own uncertainty.

The method is the product

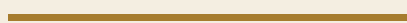


The agent loop, the claims ledger, and the judge harness are open source — re-run the whole thing on any corpus. The 10-chapter draft is the proof of output.



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Read Chapter 1 free
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Method & source — github.com/isatimur/ai-engineering-book-lab

A source-anchored, panel-graded book. If that's how AI writing should work,
a ★ helps.